SpeechGeek Presents



Female/Female Duos

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SpeechGeek Presents: F/F Duos

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One of the questions I receive most often from forensics coaches and competitors is, "Where can I find a good female/female duo?" I've never understood why it's so hard to find this kind of script. Over the years, SpeechGeek has published several scripts to meet this need, but it never seems to be enough.

You asked, we listened. This issue marks the first in our **SpeechGeek Presents** line of scripts. These special issues that fall outside of our normal publishing schedule will be used to supplement the greatest needs of coaches.

We worked for a while to figure out a title for the issue. Some of the rejected titles are listed below:

1) The Powderpuff Duo Issue
2) Take Back the Stage
3) No Fury Like a Woman: Duos for Women
4) Gypsies, Tramps, and Thieves -- Our Duos for Women Have None of These
5) Because You Can't Take "Gossip Girl" to NFL: F/F Duos.

We were close with the fifth chose, but erred on the side of brevity to get our final title.

I hope you enjoy these scripts. If you have ideas for future types of scripts for **SpeechGeek Presents**, please send an email to thegeek@speechgeek.com!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Force of Habit

by Julia Neva

SCENE 1

THIEF. (*runs in, gasping for air, and looks around quick*) Whew. For a group of grannies, those old biddies sure can move fast. But luckily for me, not fast enough to get their stuff back. (*looks into purses)* Let's see what we have here. Coupon. Coupon. Receipts from Talbots. Old Sweet-N-Low packets....that are empty. Dr. Scholl's callus removers. Used. Gross. And some cash. Thirteen dollars. *(heavy sigh*) What a rip-off.

MERCY. Having a bad day?

THIEF. (*startled)* ARGH! Holy crap, lady...

MERCY. Watch your language, child. This is a place of worship.

THIEF. *(sarcastically*) Really? Der...gee-golly-whoppers, Sister UpInMyFACE thanks for the newsflash. I couldn't figure that out with all the stained glass windows, pews and gi-normous crucifixes all over the place. This whole time I thought I was in a Burger King.

MERCY. I'm fairly certain that those purses don't belong to you.

THIEF. Wow. Now – did they teach you those super sleuthing skills in the nunnery – or did you do that all on your own?

MERCY. And I'm definitely certain that I don't like your attitude.

THIEF. Boo-hoo. Listen lady – why don't you leave me alone and go sing songs or make some soup for dirty orphans. I've got places to be.

MERCY. Tell you what. I'll give you to the count of three to get your mean, nasty, sinful self out of my chapel before I teach you a lesson.

THIEF. Oh yeah? You and what congregation?

MERCY. (*pause)* Forgive me, Father. HEEE-YAAAA! (*whirls around, kicks the back of the thief's knees, dropping the thief to the floor before whipping handcuffs around their hands)*

THIEF. AHHH! What? What? Who are you?

MERCY. Call me Mercy. Mother Mercy.

SCENE 2

(Mother Mercy is restacking books while Emma reads excitedly from the paper.)

EMMA. Wow! Mother, you're in the papers again! They can't stop talking about you! Look, this one reads: "Local would-be thief thwarted by mysterious crime-fighting nun who brings new meaning to the term 'force of habit'. This marks the third time this month the city has been made safer by the lady in black..."

MERCY. (*smiling)* Thank you Sister Emma, that's enough.

EMMA. Seriously, you're bigger than Batman.

MERCY. Humility, Emma.

EMMA. Yes, Mother.

MERCY. Thank you.

EMMA. (*beat*) But I mean, you could totally take Batman in a fight, right?

MERCY. Of course.

EMMA. If you don't mind my asking – what made you decide to do all this?

MERCY. What do you mean?

EMMA. I mean, a butt-kicking nun? Really? Doesn't that seem, I dunno, weird? After all – aren't we all supposed to take on a path of non-violence?

MERCY. I understand. It's like the old saying – there are those who do evil and those who do nothing when they see evil being done. After a while, I grew tired of seeing evil all around me. So I decided to take a stand. I don't like using force – but if the situation requires – so be it. Plus – the firm hand also works well at the potlucks and canned food drives. I've taken a couple members of this congregation down a peg or two in my time.

EMMA. (*reading paper)* Wait! Mother! Listen to this! "Local authorities have discovered the fourth disappearance of a teenage girl this week. Veronica Gragan, 15, was reported missing yesterday morning when school officials noted that she failed to attend class. Her parents said she had no history of running away and seemed to be in high spirits after returning from a concert she had attended with her friends the previous night."

MERCY. You're right, Emma. This is cause for concern. Get your things together, Emma.

EMMA. You mean?

MERCY. That's right.

EMMA. Really?

MERCY. Really. Gas up the Honda Pray-us. We've got some missing girls to find.

SCENE 3

(In Veronica's room)

MERCY. *(looking around)* My goodness. Since when did teenage girls have such messy rooms?

EMMA. Since always, Mother.

MERCY. You can barely walk through here...

EMMA. I know, Mother.

MERCY. It looks as though a trash can exploded, and then a laundry hamper threw up over the debris.

EMMA. I know...

MERCY. And what is that smell?

EMMA. Super happy vanilla bubble gum room freshener.

MERCY. It's making my sinuses shrivel. Seriously? Is my nose bleeding.

EMMA. Great. I think I just stepped in a puddle of body glitter. It'll take days to get it off.

MERCY. Well, as soon as we get young Miss Veronica home, we are going to have a talk about a little thing I like to call hygiene. Now. *(begins searching book shelf)* The first thing we need to do is figure out where this girl's diary is.

EMMA. Uh...Mother...

MERCY. *(Searching under piles)* There's a lot that's changed over the years...

EMMA. Mother....

MERCY. *(Searching under the bed, grunting)* ...but teenage girls always keep diaries.

EMMA. MOTHER!

MERCY. WHAT?

EMMA. Nobody keeps diaries anymore.

MERCY. Sweet Donny Osmond! You must be kidding me.

EMMA. Actually, no. They keep blogs.

MERCY. What?

EMMA. Blogs. Online journals. They're like diaries, only they're online and open for other people to read.

MERCY. Why on earth would you want other people reading your journal?

EMMA. I don't know. Right now, I'm trying to get into her MyFaceSpace page to see if that can give us any clues. Ugh. I can't figure out her password. Mother – I need you to tell me the name of something in her room, a diminutive adjective, and the year she was born.

MERCY. Really, Emma. That doesn't make any sense. How could HighSchoolMusicalCutie93 be a password for anything?

EMMA. Bingo. We're in.

MERCY. That was easy.

EMMA. This is weird.

MERCY. What?

EMMA. She's friends with several of the other teenage girls that have gone missing.

MERCY. She is?

EMMA. Yes. And their last messages all reference something called "The MTV Real Girl House".

MERCY. What's that?

EMMA. I don't know. I'm pulling up their website now.

SCENE 4

(*Music playing, party scenes*)

MANDY. Wassup, y'all – it's Mandy here with my bestie!

MILEY. It's Miley!

BOTH. (*screaming and giddy*) WOO!

MANDY. And we're 'bout to keep it real with you 'bout a rockin' new thang we got goin' on.

MILEY. It's totes gonna blow your extensions off your head.

MANDY. Totes.

MILEY. Yeah, totes.

MANDY. So, you guys, check this out.

MILEY. Check it.

MANDY. Yeah. So is your life, like, totally, I dunno, like this:

MILEY. (*over-acting)* UGH! I'm am, like, SO TIRED of my boring old teachers and stuid stinky parents getting all up in my business.

MANDY. Or this:

MILEY. (*over-acting)* Reading is lame! Seriously – who cares about math when you're hot!

MANDY. Seriously?

MILEY. SERIOUSLY! I wanna go somewhere where I can learn about what's really important in life – like the Cosmetic Sciences, Text Message Linguistics and Applied Mechanics of Hair Flipping.

MANDY. Well, girl, grab your keys and charge up your iPod because you gotta peep this to believe this! MTV is opening up "The Real Girl House"! The only place where Hot or Not isn't just a website...

BOTH. It's the admissions policy!

MANDY. Shut up!

MILEY. Nuh-uh, you shut up!

MANDY. So text us three photos...

MILEY. No photoshop!

MANDY. ...a link to your blog and a twenty-word essay reflecting on your own hotness and find out if you've got what it takes to make it in "The Real Girl House"!!

BOTH. Byeeee!!!!

(Mother Mercy and Sister Emma stare blankly at the computer screen for a moment.)

EMMA. (*at a loss for words)* Wow.

MERCY. Well...it looks as though we know where to find Natasha. Emma, you're going to have to wait in the Pray-Us while I go inside. If I'm not back in 10 minutes, call for the police. Okay?

EMMA. Okay.

SCENE 5

(*Loud music is playing, there are girls everywhere dancing provocatively.)*

MERCY. Sweet yams on a cracker...what kind of place is this?

GIRL. (*dancing)* Shake it...uh...shake it...uh...shake shake shake it uh...

MERCY. Excuse me, miss?

GIRL. (*still dancing)* Uhh...shake it...shake it...uh uh...

MERCY. Miss?

GIRL. (*continues to dance...not hearing Mercy*) ...Then you drop it...what? You drop it...what? You shake it then you...

MERCY. (*shouting*) I SAID, EXCUSE ME MISS!!

GIRL. (*stops and stares, silently for a beat before speaking*) Mm-hm. What are *you* s'posed to be?

MERCY. I am Mother Mercy.

GIRL. Pssht. You're not my Mama.

MERCY. No, child. I'm a nun.

GIRL. Right. I bet you ain't gettin' none dressed like that.

MERCY. None of what?

GIRL. Hahaha. Look, grandma, can I help you with somethin' are you just here to enjoy the view.

MERCY. I'm looking for girls by the name of Mandy or Miley.

GIRL. The Blonde Leaders?

MERCY. Uh...yes.

GIRL. Oh, why didn't you say so. I know a short cut. (*pulls out a bottle and sprays Mercy in the face.)*

MERCY. Ugh...what is that...why do I feel so...so...so...(ungh)

GIRL. It's Clinique's Happy Nerve Gas. Don't worry. You won't feel a thing.

SCENE 6

(Mercy is chained up and wearing a ridiculous outfit. She slowly wakes up from the gas and is horrified.)

MERCY. (yawn) What...where....where am I? And...ahhh! Where is my habit! Why are all of these clothes very tiny, bleached and frayed? I feel so scantily clad....and cold. Except for my feet. And speaking of which, where did these furry boots come from. Ugh!

MANDY. That's what they're called, idiot.

MERCY. What's called idiot?

MANDY. (*heavy sigh)* No, stupid. The furry boots are called Uggs.

MERCY. What a horrible name for a product.

MANDY. You shut your mouth you Birkenstock wearing old hag. I will not have you sully the good name of the finest footwear this side of Alaska.

MERCY. Watch your language young lady.

MANDY. Or what?

MERCY. Or I'll...

MANDY. Do what? Slap my hand with a ruler? Make me copy a page out of the dictionary? Whatev.

MERCY. Where's your other little friend?

MANDY. Miley? Puh-lease. Everyone knows that I'm the brains of this operation. Plus, (*checks watch*) she's teaching a class on Nail Polish Application Techniques in Brangelina Hall right now.

MERCY. Operation? What do you want with me? Why am I dressed like a ...

MANDY. Fashionista?

MERCY. I was going to say tundra hussy. Tomayto, tomahto.

MANDY. Ha. Ha. Ha. Very funny, Mother Mercy. Laugh it up. Better yet...why don't you break it down. (*Pulls remote control out of pocket and starts pressing buttons.)*

MERCY. (*all of the sudden her feet begin to move out of her control)* What in the...what's going on? (*her body begins to dance against her*

wishes, similar to what Girl #1 was doing) This…is…not…chaste. My hips were not…urgh…meant…to do this.

MANDY. That's the beauty of the booties. I'm trying to think up a cool name for them. I'm stuck between "Grind Control Boots" because they're like mind-control but they make you dance – or Mind-no-lo Blahniks because that sounds way hotter.

MERCY. (*dancing…still)* What's the point, Amanda.

MANDY. IT'S MANDY!

MERCY. Mandy.

MANDY. The point…Moth-er Mer-see is this: Your time is totally over. O to the V to the R. OVER. I'm tired of know-it-all goody two shoes like you running around and telling girls like me what to do, what to think and how to dress. I wanted to create a place where girls can learn about things that matter – things they can use to make them happier and prettier. Who cares about the Periodical Chart if your face is busted and you can't get a date? I give girls the one thing you can't give them: confid…conff…self esteem.

MERCY. (*still dancing)* No you don't.

MANDY. Pssht. Of course I do. And when these MTV Real Girl House confes sional cameras catch the city's do-gooder nun getting all La Vida Loca – your reputation will be ruined and I'll get tons of press.

MERCY. (*winded and exhausted)* No you're not, Mandy. Can't you see? You're hiding behind your clothes and provocative dance moves because you're scared.

MANDY. Scared of what?

MERCY. (*about to faint)* Scared that people won't like you if you're smart. Or not smart. Or just yourself. You're not empowering these girls – you're ruining their lives. They need structure and rules so they can focus on what's important.

MANDY. Oh yeah? And what's that?

MERCY. Thinking for themselves. *(looks down as feet stop moving)* Hm. Looks like your mind control boots are, as you would say, "Totally out."

MANDY. Oh crud. (*flinches)* You're not gonna like, punch me in the face now, are you?

MERCY. No, dear. (*beat*) Not unless I have to.

SCENE 7

EMMA. (*reading newspaper*) "While the network denies ever having claimed that 'The Real Girl' was an accredited institution, they do face charges for harboring runaway minors and having incredibly poor taste in programming." Ooh ooh, here's the part - "Meanwhile, government officials plan a special award for local nuns Mother Mary Mercy and Sister Emma Collins for their work in helping to return the teenagers home." (puts down paper, begins slow clap) Well done, Mother Mercy. Well done.

MERCY. Humility, Emma. Humility.

EMMA. I know…I know. But I mean, c'mon. You returned the girls! You stopped the manicured claws bratty little celebrities! You saved the day and kicked butt without having physically kicked anything. That was awesome!

MERCY. Yes, dear. But none of it would have been possible without a great amount of help.

EMMA. Well, thank you. You know, plucky, well-meaning sidekicks are so often ignored.

MERCY. Mmhm. I mean, don't forget to thank you-know-who. (*points up*)

EMMA. Oh, yeah.

(*Both bow their heads silently for a moment, then look back up.*)

MERCY. I can't wait to sit down and relax. After a long day of doing good, it will be nice to soak these old feet.

EMMA. (*picks up phone*) Hello? Yes. They're where? Okay, I'll tell her. (*holds phone*) Mother? The police are on the phone. A disgruntled former stock broker has held up a local store of a nationally dominant coffee shop chain – and they say you're the only one who can talk him down…what should I tell them?

(*Mercy looks at her and nods.*)

BOTH. To the Pray-Us!

Digging Too Deep

by Doug McConnaha

Synopsis: A college student and a professor are locked in a serious battle of wits for control. This scene involves two actors, one dressed as a college student, one as a professional. The scene is set in a small office. One chair faces the audience.

PROFESSOR. (*turns to other actor, who is seated on a stool, facing the audience*) Please look at the camera. Remember that this interview will be recorded as part of the overall project. Please state your name, year and major.

CATHY. My name is Cathy Davis, I am a freshman. My major is English Literature.

PROFESSOR. Thank you. Dream therapy is not a precise science, do you under stand that Cathy?

CATHY. Of course, I'm not really here because I need to be, this is just a dare from my friends. After your lecture to our class last week, several of us started talking about some of your theories. Person ally, I don't believe most of what you said, and I'm a natural skeptic anyway. So, when you issued your challenge to have you analyze our dreams, I thought it would be entertaining. I even called my dad after the last class and he agreed that I should be part of this demonstration – he's even read one of your books. Do your best, or your worst.

PROFESSOR. I see, so what inspired you to take my class in the first place, if you're so skeptical?

CATHY. Well, the title of the class, "The Dream as Mental Mirror," sounded, well, frankly, like a class that wouldn't be too hard, not a lot of work, you know. We were told at freshmen orientation to take at least one class that would be kind of fun, low stress, something like swim ming or beginning art. My dad told me that this would fit into my schedule better than anything else.

PROFESSOR. So you're not interested in psychology at all?

CATHY. Not at all – it's mostly smoke and mirrors, I think. This class seemed like a good break from my business classes. Who knows, maybe it'll even be worth a chuckle or two.

PROFESSOR. That's a fairly arrogant attitude from a freshman. That's even bold for a senior.

CATHY. I'm sorry, I don't mean to be disrespectful towards you, personally, professor; I just don't believe that psychologists or therapists have much credibility. It seems like a lot of guess work to me.

PROFESSOR. Have you read any of the textbook material that I assigned?

CATHY. Actually, I read more than you assigned. I already told you that my father has a copy of your book, *Discovering the Nightmares*. He gave it to me and asked me to have you autograph it. He's kind of a

fan of yours. I've read the whole book. It made me laugh.

PROFESSOR. What if I could change your mind? Last chance to back down.

CATHY. No, I don't back down. From anything. Let's get started.

PROFESSOR. Fine. I'll start by asking you to close your eyes. You must keep your eyes closed during the entire session. Do you agree and under stand?

CATHY. (*sarcastically ominous*) I hear and obey, master.

PROFESSOR. Cathy, if you are going to be rude, then we'll stop now and find someone else willing to do this.

CATHY. Sorry, professor, I was just kidding. I'll keep my eyes closed, and try to keep my mind open.

PROFESSOR. Good. Now concentrate on my voice. I want you to sit back in your chair and relax. My voice is the only sound that you should pay attention to. Take a deep breath and hold it. Wait, now, let it out slowly. Again, deep breath, pause, exhale. You are beginning to relax. Let's start with something simple. Think of a color – maybe your favorite color, maybe a color that shows up in your dreams from time to time.

CATHY. (*pause, fake snore*)

PROFESSOR. Funny. How about an answer?

CATHY. Fine. I see red, mostly. Not my favorite color, but I'll say that so we can get on with it.

PROFESSOR. Thank you. Now, I want you to think of a place, a place where you feel safe, or felt safe in the past. Is that picture in your mind?

CATHY. *(pause)* Yes.

PROFESSOR. Where is this place?

CATHY. It's my backyard. My favorite spot as a child was sitting under this big cottonwood tree. It was old and very tall.

PROFESSOR. Continue.

CATHY. That backyard was – is – the best place. In the winter, I would build snow forts and make my dad pull me in the sled. *(smiles, obviously a good memory).* Summer, though, summers were my favorite time. I was a voracious reader, even as a kid, and I would sit under the tree and read in the shade.

PROFESSOR. What else?

CATHY. Some days I didn't ever want to go back into the house – it was so peaceful in the backyard.

PROFESSOR. Do you have any particularly good memories about those times?

CATHY. I have lots of great memories of that place. Once, when I was under the tree, I fell asleep while reading a book about wizards and dragons. I had the most vivid dream that I was in the book. I was so disappointed when I woke up, because it was such a beautiful place to escape to.

PROFESSOR. Escape? Interesting word choice. What were you escaping from, Cathy?

CATHY. Nothing in particular. It was just such a good dream that I hated to

wake up from it.

PROFESSOR. Please close your eyes again, I didn't mean to interrupt your thoughts. Please go back to that moment again. What about that dream do you remember most?

CATHY. I remember that I was a princess, and I was waiting for the night, I mean, waiting for a knight to rescue me.

PROFESSOR. Rescue you from what?

CATHY. I'm not sure; I woke up before I finished the dream.

PROFESSOR. Let's finish it now. Together. Imagine that you are under the tree, and that you are warm and safe. You are asleep and the dream is beginning. What do you see?

CATHY. I see me, I'm still a child, but I'm wearing a dress like you'd see in the movies. Like a princess. The dress is light blue and I am stand ing next to a stream. The sun is shining, but I'm not alone.

PROFESSOR. Who's there with you?

CATHY. I don't know, but I suddenly feel afraid. I don't want to turn around, because it is dark behind me, even though it's daylight.

PROFESSOR. Is it a person?

CATHY. I can't tell. All I know is that it is a darkness. As dark as night. More of a presence than a person.

PROFESSOR. Why are you afraid of it?

CATHY. I sense that it wants to hurt me. I can almost feel that it hates me. I'm all alone here, no one has come to rescue me, and I can feel it getting closer to me now.

PROFESSOR. Do you want to run?

CATHY. Yes, I need to get away before it gets me.

PROFESSOR. Run, Cathy, run away from the darkness.

CATHY. I'm trying, but it is still behind me. I can hear it now. It's trying to get me. Someone help me, please!

PROFESSOR. Turn and face the darkness.

CATHY. I can't! I can't!

PROFESSOR. Yes, you can! You must! The only way the fear will stop is if you face it. Turn around.

CATHY. No, no please, don't make me!

PROFESSOR. Turn around Cathy – what do you see?

CATHY. (*screams – blood curdling and drawn out – two or three times*)

PROFESSOR. What do you see? What is it?

CATHY. (*Opens eyes and stares at Professor, wild-eyed*) It's horrible, it's, it's …(*begins to laugh*).

PROFESSOR. (*misunderstands laughter at first as tears*) Cathy, it's all right, we're all here, you're safe.

CATHY. (*still laughing*) Oh, doc, if you could see your face. You really believed that I was serious. Oh, man, this is rich. (*turns to camera*) I told you she'd fall for it. What a fake!

PROFESSOR. How dare you mock my work!

CATHY. (*suddenly very serious – low tone*) Fake, phony. Not very profes

sional, professor. Wouldn't you say? I knew you were a phony. Now everyone else does too.

PROFESSOR. So, this was a set-up?

CATHY. Better than that "doc." I came after you on purpose. Remember a woman you treated seven years ago, a woman named Carla who came to you for help and you tried your voodoo on her? She hanged herself after one of your sessions, remember that 'doc'?

PROFESSOR. Of course I do.

CATHY. I'm sure you do. My mom was scared and she trusted you, and you killed her. You and your phony bag of tricks. I was so angry at my father for trusting you, but I never let on. I hid my hate and I waited.

PROFESSOR. Cathy, I tried my best to help her, but she was very sick.

CATHY. Liar. She was just another experiment for you. I've waited seven years for this moment. I watched you walk out of that funeral service as though it was just another day. You spoke to my father and I watched him shake your hand and thank you for trying!! He shook your hand because he trusted you. HE TRUSTED YOU! I started planning on that day. Seven long years. I knew you were a fake – you didn't even know who I was until now.

PROFESSOR. *(calmly and with empathy towards Cathy)* And now you're happy? Now you feel vindicated? Now that you think you've embarrassed me? It's time to be honest with each other. Your mother came to me for help because she said that her daughter was mentally ill. She blamed herself for not being able to help you and she blamed you for being sick. She knew that it wasn't logical to be angry with you, but she couldn't help it. At the end of our last session she said everything was your fault. She didn't kill herself because of me; she killed herself because of you.

CATHY. LIAR!!! You'd say anything at this point to cover yourself.

PROFESSOR. No, remember the tree, the dream? She told me that you wouldn't stop pretending to be part of your stories, that you had lost touch with reality, that you were beginning to hurt yourself for attention. She told me that you were spending more and more time alone. That you wouldn't talk to her. A lonely little girl, with no friends but her books and her own imagination. A little girl who escaped into a fantasyland, waiting for someone to come rescue her. Your mother knew that people talked about you in whispers, that your teachers were worried about you, that your father blamed her. She was embarrassed by her failure as a mother, and that is why she took her own life.

CATHY. (*sobbing, enraged*) YOU LIAR – YOU FAKE – I HATE YOU MORE NOW THAN EVER!!

PROFESSOR. No, Cathy, I've waited seven years as well. Your father signed you up for this class, remember? It was his idea to get you some help, to pick up where I left off. I think that we've made excellent progress today.

Letters Home

by Christine Howard

(*Christine will sing the song facing upstage while Melissa puts a flower down on the memorial.)*

CHRISTINE. (*sings*) *Where have all the young men gone? Long time passing. Where have all the young men gone? Long time ago. Where have all the young men gone? Gone for soldiers every one. When will they ever learn? When will they ever learn?*

MELISSA. (holds *up picture to audience*) This is my husband, Kevin. We were high school sweethearts. It's hard to believe that we've only been married three months and are already apart from one another. He got deployed just a couple of months after the wedding. I miss him. And it's been really difficult since he's been in Iraq. If we can just make it through these next few months, then he will be home and we can be together. I can't lose hope, but it's hard when the news is talking about so many of our soldiers dying over there. That's why I wanted to come here today, to show my support…

(*They rotate.*)

CHRISTINE. (*holds up picture to audience*) This is my brother, Mike. He got deployed to Iraq late last year. I'll never forget the day he called us to tell us that he was being deployed. I had this sick feeling in the pit of my stomach. I just knew that something horrible was going to happen, you know? It's funny—when Mike and I were little kids, we always wanted to be the person who was right in an argument. Well, it ends up that I was right about Mike being in Iraq. What I wouldn't give to have been wrong this time…

END OF TEASER

CHRISTINE. (*reads letter aloud*) *Dear Sis—It seems like I've been here for so much longer than I have. My life away from here seems so far away. In some ways, I don't think I'll ever have it back completely. I think war takes certain things from you, or maybe it gives certain things that change your perspective. In the past two nights we've been attacked each night while on patrol. No casualties for us.… I see more bravery in a day here than I had seen in my entire life prior to this. We got a blow to our morale a few days ago when the corps commander visited us. He said there was no way we were going home in less than nine to twelve months. Man, that's going to suck. We're working on month number four right now and it already seems like we've been here forever and a day. I still love being a commander. I love leading troops and taking care of them. It is a huge responsibility and I feel the weight of it every day. I send the thing I love most out here — my men — into harm's way every day and every night. I just do my best to ensure they're ready, trained, equipped and properly led in every situation. Hey—It's still pretty warm during the day, but gets very chilly at night. Could you try and find one of my hooded sweatshirts to send to me? Stay safe, sis—love you, Mike*

MELISSA. Hi—are you here to pay tribute to someone? I'm Melissa, by the way—

CHRISTINE. Hi, I'm Christine. And yes—I'm here to pay tribute to my brother, Mike. He got killed in Iraq last month. My mom and dad couldn't bear it to come here to the memorial, but I had to be here. Did you lose someone, too?

MELISSA. Me? No, my husband, Kevin, has been over there for a couple of months—he supposed to be there for a year. But with this stop-loss executive order, we don't really know.

CHRISTINE. I know—it's hard not knowing an exact date. Are you okay?

MELISSA. I don't know. I just don't know anymore.

CHRISTINE. So, have you heard from your husband lately? I'm not trying to pry, I just can see the worry on your face. And I guess what I told you about Mike doesn't help much. I'm sorry.

MELISSA. No, no, it's okay. I'm so sorry about your brother. I can only imagine what it must be like to get that news. Sometimes I wake up in the middle of the night wondering if I am going to get that phone call. And when I don't get an e-mail from Kevin at least every other day, my mind automatically goes to the worst possible scenario. I just can't help but think the worst, you know?

CHRISTINE. I understand. So, you get to talk to Kevin quite a bit, huh?

MELISSA. I can't imagine not being able to talk to him as much as I do. Can you imagine what the families of soldiers overseas did before cell phones and e-mail? It had to be a lesson in patience. I mean just the other day, Kevin and I were talking for a least a half an hour and I (*sees that she is upsetting Christine*)…I'm sorry—I didn't mean to make you think about—

CHRISTINE. You didn't do anything wrong. I think about him every single day. It's been a month today since we got the news. We just buried him a couple of weeks ago. It took a little longer to get his body back to the states and then we had so many people to get in touch with that it's just been one long, horrible nightmare. I thought if I came to this memorial that I could get a little closure, you know? Talk to some people who know how I'm feeling. I have to say that I'm glad you have no idea how I'm feeling right now, but I'm happy that you don't mind talking to me about it.

MELISSA. If you don't mind my asking, how did Mike die?

CHRISTINE. He was killed when a bomb detonated under his vehicle. The details are a little sketchy, but it doesn't really matter now, I guess.

Editor's Note: In the printed edition, pg. 16-17 are the advertisment found at the end of this file.

He's gone. I just hope that someone was there to comfort him when he died. The thought of him being alone…

(*Christine faces front and Melissa will rotate to back*)

Dear Sis,
I'm writing to you with some news, but you have to promise me that you won't tell mom about it. I got into a sort of accident, if that's what you call it. We were hit by a rocket-propelled grenade (what we call an RPG), which set our truck on fire because it struck the battery and fuel line. My neck and shoulder were pretty banged up for about two weeks. My shoulder popped and I jammed my neck as well. I lost my hearing in my left ear for a few weeks. My hearing in general isn't good at all anymore. I've been through my share of explosives. I'm sending pictures home to be developed of my truck (or what's left of it). I took a few of me with the truck, so you could all see that I'm O.K. Right now I'm soaking my feet. My feet take a beating in these boots. My feet are all cut up and sore. . . . I guess I haven't been taking as good care of myself this month. We have a physical training test I'm getting ready for. This month and last we haven't gotten much time to do P.T. So I work, sleep, work, P.T., work — oh, and eat. Well sis, my 20-minute soak is up. Take care. I love you. Don't worry so much about me—my intuition has already saved a few lives here and my own as well. Love, Mike

MELISSA. Christine, may I ask you something?

CHRISTINE. Sure—anything you want.

MELISSA. Do you ever think that this war is a huge mistake? Do you wonder if we're even doing any good over there? Or maybe that your brother—and possibly my husband—are just sacrificing them selves for nothing?

CHRISTINE. Truthfully? Yes, I've thought about that, but when I read one of Mike's letters I know that he died doing what he loved. He was so proud of this country and I know that he died a true hero. I know you're worried, but you know that Kevin is over there because he wants to fight for his country.

MELISSA. I know. And I am so proud of my husband. It's just that the last time I talked to him on the phone, he seemed really out of sorts, espe cially when I told him that I was—

CHRISTINE. You were what?

MELISSA. Kevin and I are going to have a baby. We're due in December. I know it's really good news—I had a feeling about when he got deployed, but I didn't want to tell him until I knew for sure. And I hated having to tell him over the phone when he was thousands of miles away. It didn't seem fair. I know that I signed up for this life when we got married, but every single day I think about him and how he may never get to meet our child. And I hate it! I just don't know how your brother and my husband put their lives on the line

every day when they seem to get no respect or support!

CHRISTINE. It's okay. I know—I look at the headlines and wonder how many people really understand what they're going through over there. That's why I wanted to be here today. And just look at all of these people who came out with the flags and their candles and photo graphs of their soldiers. Listen—you have to stay positive. You're going to have a baby! I'm sure Kevin was thrilled when you told him.

MELISSA. He was—I could just hear the fear in his voice, though—listen, enough about me. Tell me more about Mike and his letters.

CHRISTINE. Mike? Oh, he was the best brother anyone could ever have—we fought like cats and dogs, but we were so close. I printed up all of his e-mails. We even read some of them at his funeral. I keep them with me to remember him every day.

MELISSA. Would you read one to me, please?

CHRISTINE. Really? Um, sure—this is the last one I got from him—

Dear Sis—Man, do I miss you all—but I have some great news. I'm getting a Purple Heart for the accident, along with eight other people in my platoon. . . . Someone is always getting injured here. There have been no fatalities so far in my company, though, just lots of injuries. Oh, and someone shot at us last night. I was getting ready to go to sleep and I hear a pop, pop, and then the bullets ricocheted off the building right outside the window I was standing in front of. . . . It kinda sucks, when all you can think about is there's someone out there trying to kill you or your buddy next to you, and all you can do is hope you kill them first. But hey—Eighteen days till my birthday! I can't wait! No one probably even knows when it is over here. Well, bye for now, just wanted to let you know I'm O.K. and I miss you, mom and dad. See you soon, little sister—love you—Mike.

MELISSA. Thanks, Christine.

CHRISTINE. No, thank you—I haven't talked about Mike to anyone since the funeral—it means so much to know that someone cares. Listen—everything is going to be okay. Kevin is going to come home and you two can begin your lives with the new baby. You're going to be fine.

MELISSA. Well, it looks like the service is about to start. It was great to talk to you. I hope that your family knows how much I appreciate Mike's service to his country.

CHRISTINE. We know—good luck with the baby. Congrats—you take care of yourself, okay?

MELISSA. We will. Bye…

(*Christine rotates to the back, Melissa speaks to audience*)

MELISSA. Two weeks after the memorial, I lost my husband. Army Specialist

Kevin A. Givens was killed June 12 when his tank fell into the Euphrates River after the bank on which he was parked gave way. Kevin and I had been talking quite a bit between the memorial and when we lost him. We had so many great conversations about the baby—we found out that we were having a boy. He was so thrilled! Our son, Kevin Michael Givens, was born on December 29, just a few months after his father died. He looks just like his dad. Every time I look in my son's eyes, I see my husband. I just wish that Kevin had gotten to meet his son. I try to make him proud, but it's just so hard. I wonder sometimes how I can ever get through this. I got this letter in the mail just a week after Kevin was killed-

Dearest Melissa,

I never thought that I would be writing a letter like this. I really don't know where to start. I've been getting bad feelings, though and, well, if you are reading this. . . .

To my baby boy, I never got to see you, but I know in my heart you are beautiful. I know you will be strong and big-hearted like your mom. I will always have with me the joy I felt when I found out you were on your way. I love you.

Melissa, I have never been as blessed as the day I met you. You are my angel, soulmate, wife, and best friend. I'm sorry. I did not want to have to write this letter. There is so much more I need to say, so much more I need to share. A lifetime's worth. I married you for a million lifetimes. That's how long I will be with you. Please keep our son safe. Please find it in your heart to forgive me for leaving you alone. . . . Teach our son to live life to the fullest and please tell yourself to do the same.

I will always be there with you, Melissa. I will always want you, need you and love you, in my heart, my mind and my soul. Do me a favor, after you tuck the baby in, go outside and look at the stars and count them. That's where you'll see me—loving you from above and watching over you and our son. Always and forever.

Your husband,
Kevin

CHRISTINE. (*sings from facing upstage as Melissa looks up to the stars*) *Where have all the soldiers gone? Long time passing. Where have all the soldiers gone? Long time ago. Where have all the soldiers gone? Gone for graveyards every one. When will they ever learn? When will they ever learn?*

Nightmares

by Doug McConnaha

This scene involves two females, both dressed as high school students. The scene is in a living room, two chairs with a cover for the couch, and one other chair stage left.
Synopsis: an innocent sleepover turns into a nightmare.

MELANIE. (*on the phone*) So then what did your dad say about your grades? No way, he can't ground you just because you get a "D" for the quarter; only the semester grade really counts. Yeah, I know, your dad's really pretty nice, but he's way too hung up on grades. (*looks at watch*). I can't believe that it's already 10:30 and Becky's not here yet. She said that she'd be here right after she got off work at 10. What a way to spend a Friday night, stuck at home, waiting for Becky to show up. Hey! Don't talk about my best friend like that. I don't care if she drives you crazy; we've been friends since third grade.

BECKY. *(walks into room, sees Melanie on phone, slowly sneaks up behind her and then scares her)* HAH! Gotcha!!

MELANIE. (*screams, then angry*) That's not funny, you could have hurt me.

BECKY. Don't be such a wimp!

MELANIE. (*looks at phone, then speaks into it*) Sorry Bobby, I've got to go, Becky's here, and I'll call you back tomorrow. Yes, she's spending the night.

BECKY. (*obnoxiously into phone*) Yes, Bobby dear, we're going to stay up all night and watch scary movies and talk about boyfriends. (*overdone "blown kisses"*)

MELANIE. Ignore her, Bobby, I do. Bye. (*hangs up phone and turns to Becky*) You are such a jerk. Bobby and I were having an important discus sion and you just butt right in. Who let you in here, anyhow?

BECKY. You left the door unlocked again. I should have stayed around the corner and listened to you talk to Bobbie. Who knows what I might have learned?

MELANIE. What Bobbie and I talk about is none of your business. You should have knocked until I answered instead of just coming in.

BECKY. I did knock once, but then the door popped open, so I came in. You know, the biggest danger of me hearing your conversation with Bobbie is that I'd be stupider for having listened.

MELANIE. Funny. Besides, I always tell you everything we talk about anyway.

BECKY. And don't think that I'm not fascinated with your love life, because I'm not. So, what did he say?

MELANIE. He said that his dad wasn't going to let up on him. He's still grounded until his grades come up.

BECKY. My folks wouldn't dare ground me for bad grades – they'd be too

tired of having me home all the time. Look at the bright side – this way Bobbie can work on his homework and you and I can hang out. I brought food and movies to last all night.

MELANIE. If my folks knew that I was letting you spend the night, they'd never have gone out of town in the first place.

BECKY. What do your folks have against me?

MELANIE. Face it Becky, whenever you come over, something gets broken or wrecked. My dad still doesn't know that it was you who put the scratch on his car, and not me. I lost my driving privileges for two weeks for driving without permission, and I wasn't even behind the wheel.

BECKY. Oh, poor little Mel gets punished. That must've gone on the calendar. "Miss perfect sent to her room." You should have told the truth and said it was me.

MELANIE. Oh, yeah, my dad would have gone ballistic. You're not exactly his favorite person anyway. You would have been banned from my house for life.

BECKY. Well, I'm here now, so let's get this party going.

MELANIE. (*looking at the videotapes*) Oh, come on Becky, you promised me that we wouldn't watch scary movies. I thought that you were just teasing me when you said that to Bobby.

BECKY. Scary movies are the best. Stop being such a coward.

MELANIE. You know how I feel about stuff like that. Ever since I was a little kid, I've hated those kinds of shows. Pick something else.

BECKY. Why? Why do you hate them? What are you afraid of?

MELANIE. I don't want to tell you. It's personal; besides, I was just a little kid.

BECKY. Come on; tell me, I can keep a secret.

MELANIE. (*struggles*) No, just forget it.

BECKY. Are you kidding, I have to hear it now.

MELANIE. Look, when I was a kid I used to have nightmares ok. Just drop it.

BECKY. What about?

MELANIE. Leave it alone. If I start talking about it, I'll start to have them again. Look, I've got goose bumps now. Thanks, Becky, I'll really sleep good tonight.

BECKY. We weren't planning on sleeping anyway, so… talk to me. I didn't know you had nightmares. You never said anything about it.

MELANIE. Remember in fourth grade, you had a slumber party, and I went home early because I was sick? I wasn't sick OK? I was afraid that you'd find out about the dreams and you'd all laugh at me.

BECKY. Ok, so, I'm not laughing now. I'm listening.

MELANIE. (*takes a moment, drinks some pop, then starts*) When I was a little girl, maybe seven or eight, my folks took my older sister and I to a movie one night. My dad really wanted us to see this movie, he said that it would be really scary and he thought we'd all like it. My mom didn't want to go, so my dad just took us girls. The movie was so scary that I started to cry. My dad leaned over in the seat and told

me to be quiet. He said to grow up and knock it off. I couldn't help it, I was really scared. Angie was really into it, not even scared.

BECKY. She's five years older than you.

MELANIE. I know. So there I was, this terrified eight-year-old in a theatre with a bunch of people screaming and laughing and these horrible images on the screen, and no one cared. So, I started to cry even louder. My dad picked me up, carried me into the lobby and said, "Look, I didn't raise you to be crybaby. It's only a movie, so what are you crying for?" My dad was so mad, and I couldn't stop sobbing. So, he sat me down on a bench by the door, told me to sit there until I was ready to stop crying or until the movie was over. Then he went back in to watch the movie. I just sat there and sobbed. My own dad left me there alone. I cried until I started to throw up. I ran into the bathroom and got sick. When I started to leave, the door to the bathroom wouldn't open. I wasn't strong enough to pull it open; you know how heavy those doors are down at the Park Theatre. I was stuck in that horrible smelling old room until the movie got out. Dad and Angie had been looking for me for about 10 minutes before they realized that I was in there. Dad even called home to see if I'd tried to call mom for a ride. When we got home, mom and dad had this huge argument about the whole thing. I cried myself to sleep that night, listening to them fighting, and watching the shadows on the wall moving. That was the first night I had the nightmares, and I had them for almost three years, off and on. Even now, when I get a whiff of movie popcorn, for a second, I can remember the whole experience.

BECKY. How sad, your dad doesn't seem like such a mean guy.

MELANIE. He's not mean; he just thought I'd like it. He apologized for days and tried to make up for it.

BECKY. So, what you're telling me is that you got scared as a little kid, and you won't watch any more scary movies. Come on, Mel, you're almost seventeen years old. Get over it. (*like a campfire story – trying to be spooky*) Listen, I read a story in a magazine not too long ago that was even scarier than that. This little girl was watch ing a movie about a man who kills his wife, cuts her up and puts in the freezer. The kid began to realize that they had a freezer just like that in the basement. So, she goes downstairs…

MELANIE. Quit it, now you're just trying to scare me.

BECKY. No, really. This actually happened. The little girl opened the freezer and there was her all this meat wrapped in white paper. She took one out, unwrapped it, and there was her mom's hand! Her dad had killed her and they had been living off of it. The little girl had been told that her mom had run off. That kid is in the state mental hospital to this day.

MELANIE. You're sick; you know that, you'd make up some story like that just to tease me, just to get me upset, just to make fun of me. You always

made fun of me, and now, I'm really scared.

BECKY. (*casually*) Relax, Jamie, I'm right here, and there's nothing to be afraid of.

MELANIE. (*on-edge*) Wait a minute. When you came in, you said that the door was unlocked. But I locked it! I even put the chain on it.

BECKY. No, you didn't. The door wasn't even shut tight.

MELANIE. Becky, someone's in the house with us. I kept hearing sounds earlier, but I thought it was the rain or the wind or something.

BECKY. *(suddenly serious)* It's not raining. It stopped before I ever got off work.

MELANIE. We have to get out of here now.

BECKY. *(with an edge to her voice)* Look, Mel, you are starting to get weird and now you're scaring me. There is no one else here.

(*Both jump and turn at "sound".)*

MELANIE. What was that?

BECKY. That sounded like a door closing.

MELANIE. Someone's in the other room.

BECKY. *(maintaining control)* No, don't be silly. I didn't shut the door tight when I came in. I was sneaking up on you, remember? I'll go check.

MELANIE. No, don't go in there, we can run out the back door.

BECKY. What good will that do us? Two girls standing outside a perfectly safe house. Besides, I left my car keys in my coat, so I have to go in there if we are going to "get away."

MELANIE. Don't you dare leave me alone again!! Not now!!

BECKY. *(snaps angrily)* Melanie, you're not eight years old anymore, and there is nothing to be afraid of. Stop being such a crybaby!! (*pause*) I'm sorry; I didn't mean to say that. I'll be right back. I'll get my coat; we'll go to my house for a while. (*leaves*)

MELANIE. Becky… Did you find your coat? Becky? Stop teasing me, I'm not kidding at all. Answer me.

BECKY. (*blood curdling scream – make it good!!!)*

(Melanie screams, drops to the floor and begins to sob hysterically.)

BECKY. (*pops around corner and shouts*) Gotcha again!

(*Melanie doesn't react, just sobs.*)

BECKY. (*sits on floor with Melanie*) Oh Mel, I'm so sorry. Mel?

Metamorph

by Julia Neva

SCENE 1 — Premonitions

ANNE. I know it's not very original, but like every other little girl, I dreamed of being an actress. The dream always starts off the same.

PHOTOG. Anne! Anne!

ANNE. It's just an ordinary day, so boring and average and its almost alarming.

PHOTOG. C'mon, Anne. Over here!

ANNE. And then some slick haired talent agent spies me. At the mall. Or the grocery store. They say:

PHOTOG. Hey beautiful!

ANNE. Or…

PHOTOG. That's what we're looking for!

ANNE. And before you can blink, I walk the red carpet and I'm lit up by flash bulbs like a Christmas tree. I'm a household name.

PHOTOG. Show us some love, Anne.

ANNE. What little girl doesn't dream of everyone watching her every move? Of slipping into a new role, a new character, a new life – as easily as slipping into a new dress? That dream of transformation, changing and becoming something so monumental that even if for a brief moment, everything is altered. But who am I kidding?

PHOTOG. You're killing me, Anne. Give me something to work with! I got a wife and kids to support!

ANNE. No little girl would ever dream of a life like this.

PHOTOG. C'mon. Give us a smile.

SCENE 2 — In the beginning

ANNE. (*flipping through the television channels*) Ugh. No. No. No. *Law and Order*. Nope. *Spongebob*. Nuh-uh. *Heroes*. Maybe. *Baby Story.* (beat) No thank you. (pause – looks at book next to her.) Well Pre-Calculus, looks like it's you and me.

ELIZABETH. (*enters from off-stage*) Anne?

ANNE. In here, mom.

ELIZABETH. Did you get the mail?

ANNE. Yeah.

ELIZABETH. Where is it?

ANNE. Kitchen table.

ELIZABETH. Found it.

ANNE. Woo.

ELIZABETH. Don't be smart.

ANNE. Okay. (*picks up book*) Guess this is good-bye, Pre-Cal. Parting is such sweet sorrow.

ELIZABETH. Cute. Care to explain why you decided to stay home from school today?

ANNE. Wow. Don't go overboard with the concerned, nurturing mother routine. I dunno. I've been exhausted lately and was throwing up this morning. So what?

ELIZABETH. I wasn't born yesterday, Anne. Are you hung over?

ANNE. What?

ELIZABETH. Did you consume alcoholic bev-

ANNE. I know what hung over means, mom. I mean, what are you asking me that for?

ELIZABETH. You're seventeen.

ANNE. Yeah. And?

ELIZABETH. Seventeen year old girls are drawn to boys, beers and bank accounts. Seeing as how you already have a generous allowance, I assume you've been distracted by the other two. And I'd rather ask questions now than deal with issues later.

ANNE. Listen, mom, it's probably just a stomach flu. Wanna explain why you're snapping at the drop of a hat as of late?

ELIZABETH. I'm sorry, sweetheart. (*gives her a peck on the forehead)* It's August. It's an election year– and needless to say – a pretty big one for your mom here.

ANNE. Yeah. Woo-hoo. Go mom. Lady power, and what not.

ELIZABETH. Thank you dear. I've been running around like a chicken with my head cut off trying to get all of the campaign stops organized.

ANNE. Careful. That's not the kind of language that wins over the animal rights activists.

ELIZABETH. (*sarcastic*) Why am I not paying you to run my campaign? You're obviously so insightful. And plus – we'd get to spend more time together.

ANNE. No kidding. I barely see you anymore. It's any wonder I still recognize you.

ELIZABETH. I know, dear. I'm sorry. I promise that once the election is over we will go off for a weekend, just us girls. We'll get pedicures. Order room service. Watch a movie. Spend some quality time together. But right now, your old mom has a lot on her plate right now – and I've got to do everything possible to secure my election as gover nor. Once that happens, it will be smooth sailing for Governor Elizabeth Wright and daughter.

ANNE. Okay.

ELIZABETH. Now go get some rest. If you're still throwing up tomorrow morning, we'll call and get you in to see a doctor.

SCENE 3 — One week later

(*Both Anne and Elizabeth stand silently for a few beats. Neither are looking at each other. You could cut the tension with a knife. Easily. After a few moments, Elizabeth speaks in a low, angry voice.*)

ELIZABETH. How long?

ANNE. What?

ELIZABETH. How. Long.

ANNE. I don't know...

ELIZABETH. (*building*) How long did you know you were pregnant before you were going to tell me?

ANNE. I didn't.

ELIZABETH. Anne, look at me.

ANNE. Mom, I think you're over-re...

ELIZABETH. (*cuts her off abruptly*) Shh! I don't want to hear you speak. I don't want to hear your voice unless it is answering a question that I ask. Do you understand?

ANNE. Mom...

ELIZABETH. Do you understand? (*Anne nods*) Okay. Who is the boy?

ANNE. Josh.

ELIZABETH. Josh, who?

ANNE. Josh Rieser.

ELIZABETH. The lacrosse player? (*Anne nods*) How convenient. How long have you two been together?

ANNE. A couple of months.

ELIZABETH. (*Laughs*). Oh! How sweet. A couple of months. I can see why it was such a wise decision to... Honestly, Anne. What on earth were you thinking?

ANNE. Mom, we used protection.

ELIZABETH. Obviously it wasn't very protective, now was it?

ANNE. Mom...

ELIZABETH. Don't "mom" me. Do you get what you've done?

ANNE. Mom...please. Just let me speak.

ELIZABETH. (*to self*) Oh, now she feels like talking about it. Not a couple of months earlier when we could have done something about this. Please, Anne. Speak. I'm absolutely *dying* to hearhwhat you have to say for yourself.

ANNE. Okay. (*heavy sigh*) Look. I made a mistake. I didn't do this on purpose. Which is what a mistake is, I guess. But I already feel horrible about it, I've made myself sick over it and I don't need you piling on the guilt. I need your help. I'm scared. Confused. I don't...

ELIZABETH. (*comforting her*) Shhh...c'mere sweetheart. I know this wasn't something you had planned, but I'm going to have to make some calls to see what we should do now.

ANNE. What do you mean?

ELIZABETH. Well, by the time the election rolls around you could be anywhere from 4-5 months pregnant. All it takes is for the word to leak out to the wrong person and the press and my opponents and...

ANNE. ...and everyone else can be as supportive and caring as you have been?

ELIZABETH. Yes. Look, let me make some calls. But in the meantime – you

cannot tell anyone about this.

ANNE. But…wouldn't it just be easier to come clean? Make a public statement and you know, spin it in your benefit?

ELIZABETH. I'm running on a family values platform. Those don't exactly include unwed teenage mothers.

ANNE. I guess.

ELIZABETH. Just keep your mouth shut and we may get through this in one piece. Okay?

SCENE 4 — 3 months later

ANNE. (*on the phone*) Okay, Lisa. Listen…I've gotta tell you something, but you've got to promise you won't tell anyone. (…) No. (..) Seriously. (…) Lisa, ugh, I swear… I'm gonna punch you in the face if you don't shut up for two seconds and let me (…) what? (…) No. Go back to what you just said. (…) What do you mean everyone knows about it? (…) How? (…) Josh said what? (…) No. No. NO!!! (…) Maybe I'm flipping out. Maybe it's not that big of a deal. Maybe it's just the people at school.

SCENE 5 – Grocery Shopping

PHOTOGRAPHER. (*keeps the pace of the conversation fairly quick*) Excuse me, miss?

ANNE. Huh?

PHOTOG. You're Anne Wright, right?

ANNE. (*hesitant*) Yeah…

PHOTOG. (*jotting down in a notebook*) And you're mother is Elizabeth Wright.

ANNE. Yeah….

PHOTOG. And she's running for governor…

ANNE. Yeah, I'm sorry – who are you and what are you getting at?

PHOTOG. Can I get your picture real quick?

ANNE. Uh…(*photographer snaps photo before she can respond*) Hey!

PHOTOG. Any truth to the rumor you're four months pregnant?

ANNE. Where did you hear that?

PHOTOG. I take it that's a yes?

ANNE. Who are you?

PHOTOG. Dana Bell, from The Daily Report. Do you know who the father is?

ANNE. (*turning to leave*) Leave me alone.

PHOTOG. C'mon, Anne. Just answer a couple of questions.

ANNE. No. Go away.

PHOTOG. Won't take but a few minutes…

ANNE. I said GO AWAY!

PHOTOG. You shouldn't be so defensive if you don't have anything to hide.

ANNE. STOP IT! I just – I just want to be left alone, okay. Please…whatever you…

PHOTOG. (*shouts after her*) You can't hide the truth, kiddo. It'll eventually come out. (*looks down*). She forgot her groceries (*looks in bag*)

with her prenatal vitamins. Perfect.

SCENE 6 – At Home

ANNE. (*on the verge of tears*) I can't believe this. I can't be

ELIZABETH. (*on the phone*) Listen, I've told every other yahoo from your publication that I do not now, nor will I ever comment on this issue. If you want to ask me about my stance on the platform issues I'll give you an hour-long interview. Just leave my daughter alone.

(*Hangs up the phone and sighs*)

ANNE. What did they say?

ELIZABETH. The same as the others. They wanted me to confirm your pregnancy. They won't take no for an answer. Nor will they retract the reports they've already put out there.

ANNE. Ohhh…why (*starts to cry*)

ELIZABETH. Shh….

ANNE. My life is over.

ELIZABETH. No it's not, dear.

ANNE. Yes it is mom. As if it's already not bad enough that the whole school thinks I'm a slut – now the whole world does?

ELIZABETH. Nobody thinks that

ANNE. Yes they do, mom. What – you think I haven't turned a television on or read a newspaper? I'm horrified. Isn't there any way we can fix this? Anything we can say?

ELIZABETH. The best we can do is to not say anything. Besides – the election is in two days. Once it's over then they will leave us both alone.

ANNE. Yeah, because I will have cost you your shot at governor. Every thing is ruined!!

ELIZABETH. We don't know that.

ANNE. Please, mom…(*stops and doubles over in pain*) Oww…..

ELIZABETH. Anne…?

ANNE. Ugh…I think I'm having contractions.

ELIZABETH. There's no way. You're only 4 ½ months along.

ANNE. It hurts. (*moans*) Mom…

ELIZABETH. This can't be good. Let's get you to the hospital.

ANNE. Mom…

ELIZABETH. Just hold on, dear.

SCENE 7 – The Concession

PHOTOG. Ms. Wright!

ELIZABETH. Yes. You.

PHOTOG. Do you have anything to say to your opponent, Mark Richards?

ELIZABETH. I would like to be the first to congratulate Mr. Richards on a well-fought campaign for the governor's office. It's been a difficult few months leading up to tonight, but I'm sure he will serve our state well in the months to come.

PHOTOG. Ms. Wright, is there anything you would have changed in your

campaign?

ELIZABETH. Well, I'd be foolish not to believe that hindsight is 20/20. There are always mistakes and missed opportunities along the way, but that's life. That's what it means to be human.

PHOTOG. Ms. Wright: we've noticed that your daughter Anne isn't here with you tonight.

ELIZABETH. No. She's not. Unfortunately my daughter is being treated in the hospital for…health complications brought on by extreme amounts of stress. She's in bed watching this as we speak and I can only hope she's feeling better.

PHOTOG. We're sorry to hear that.

ELIZABETH. Are you? Because I'm fairly sure it rests on the shoulders of individuals such as yourself who are more concerned about breaking salacious gossip first than worrying about the impacts such stories have on individuals and their family members. Sure – you hide behind the notion that "The people have the right to know" or that my private life or the lives of my family members somehow impact my ability to do my job. But in the end, you're hiding in public and hoping that the people at home – the people I wanted to serve as governor – don't see through your lousy mud-slinging journalism. Learn how to do your job and leave innocent people out of it. I'm sure this rant has given you plenty of fodder for the evening news. In the mean time – I've got more important issues to tend to. Thank you to my supporters and have a wonderful evening.

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